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middle east - 4 lawmakers from L.A. area join California group in Israel

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Four Los Angeles-area state legislators are in Israel this week visiting with politicians and families on both sides of the conflict as criticisms of the Israeli invasion of the Gaza Strip and calls for a cease-fire continue to rise at home.

Sen. Henry Stern of Calabasas and Assemblymembers Al Muratsuchi of Torrance, Jesse Gabriel of the San Fernando Valley and Josh Lowenthal of Long Beach are part of the group.

The purpose of the trip is to

“meet with impacted communities and bear witness to the devastation caused by the Oct. 7 Hamas attack and resulting Israel-Hamas war, both of which have had significant impacts on communities across California,” according to a joint statement by the seven lawmakers on the trip.

Also on the trip are state Sen. Scott Wiener of San Francisco and Assemblymembers Esmeralda Soria of Fresno and Damon Connolly of San Rafael.

During the trip, the Democratic legislators will “visit impacted communities on the Israel-Gaza border and engage in a series of intensive meetings with a diverse group of government and community leaders,” the statement said. The legislators arrived on Tuesday and are scheduled to depart on Sunday.

Militants with Hamas — considered a terrorist group by Israel and the U.S. — killed about 1,200 people in the Oct. 7 attack and took 250 hostages. Since then, more than 28,000 Palestinians have been killed in Israel’s offensive against Hamas in Gaza, according to the latest estimates from the Hamas-run Ministry of Health.

Earlier this week, the Israeli government announced its intent to invade the southern Gaza city of Rafah, which President Joe Biden said he opposes unless Israel can ensure the safety of its 1 million residents.

Wiener and Gabriel are co-chairs of the California Jewish Legislative Caucus and Stern is a member. They are joined in Israel by representatives from the San Francisco Jewish Community Relations Council, Jewish Public Affairs Committee of California and Jewish Federation of Los Angeles.

“Our hope is that these elected officials can understand the complexity of the moment, the pain of our community, the fragility of this moment, and work to support and safeguard our communities here in Los Angeles, upon their return,” said Joanna Mendelson senior vice president of community engagement at the Jewish Federation Los Angeles.

The scheduled stops include meetings with Israeli President Isaac Herzog; Jewish and Arab members of the Israeli Parliament; families of Israeli hostages; Rami Nazzal, a Palestinian reporter for The New York Times; the leaders of Yad b’ Yad, a joint Israeli-Palestinian dual-language school; and LGBTQ leaders in Be’er Sheva.

Also on the agenda are visits to the site of the Supernova Music Festival and kibbutz Kfar Aza, both of which saw mass casualties during the Oct. 7 attack.

The California Legislature, like the constituents they represent, are divided in their stance on the ongoing conflict.

Several lawmakers — such as Assemblymembers Alex Lee of San Jose, Matt Haney of San Francisco and Liz Ortega

of the East Bay — have called for an immediate cease-fire, the Sacramento Bee reported. On Jan. 4, hundreds of protestors disrupted the first day of the Legislature's session to call for a cease-fire in Gaza.

Members of the Jewish Legislative Caucus have acknowledged the atrocities in Gaza, but also emphasized the need to protect Israeli hostages and Jewish Californians.

"We have our own criticisms of Israel. We want the war to end," said Wiener in a statement following the Jan. 4 protest. "We also know the cease-fire resolutions we see at the local level have at times gone off the rails in terms of dredging up a lot of anti-Jewish hate, and that causes a lot of fear in our community."

Sen. Henry Stern was personally impacted by the November death of a Jewish man who participated in dueling Israel-Palestine rallies in Thousand Oaks, an area Stern represents. Palestinian protestor Loay Abdelfattah Alnaji was charged with involuntary manslaughter in the death of Paul Kessler, who died after being shoved and hitting his head on the pavement.

"What's so strange about Oct. 7 and everything that has happened since is we don't need to make this a history lesson or remember this; hate is here now," said Stern at a November event at Kessler's memorial. "I'm getting a car swerving at me on the road, yelling epithets at me when I'm walking with a kippah on a Saturday with my 2-year-old daughter."

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